Minorities

Five communities-Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, and Parsis-notified by the government as minority communities constitute 18.42 per cent of total population as per the 2001 Census. The Eleventh Five Year Plan, a three pronged strategy including:

(i) Educational empowerment,

(ii) Area development, and

(iii) Economic empowerment of minority communities was adopted.

Educational empowerment was sought through three scholarship schemes, namely, Pre-matric, Post-matric, and Merit-cum-means based, with more than 1 crore scholarships. These schemes were supplemented by the activities of the Maulana Azad Education Foundation (MAEF). Economic empowerment is sought to be achieved through infusion of credit under priority-sector lending (PSL) by banks and through credit provided by the National Minorities Development and Finance Corporation (NMDFC). Efforts are also being made to improve the management of Wakf properties and a scheme for computerisation of Wakf Board records is a significant step in this direction. The Wakf Amendment Bill 2010 has also been introduced in Parliament to improve and streamline the functioning of Wakf Boards in India.

Persons with Disabilities

A number of schemes are being implemented for the empowerment and rehabilitation of **persons with disabilities**. These schemes aim to promote physical, psychological, social, educational, and economic rehabilitation and development of persons with disabilities to enhance their quality of life and enable them to lead their lives with dignity. There are seven autonomous national institutes working in different fields of disabilities. These institutes are engaged in human resource development in the field of disability, providing rehabilitation services to persons with disabilities and undertaking research and development in their respective areas of specialisations. Besides, in order to facilitate the creation of infrastructure and capacity building at the district level for awareness generation, rehabilitation, and training and guiding rehabilitation professionals, the